didn’t even know I had. On drives suddenly. Cover drives through point. Sashays and punches down the ground.

When tea comes around, England have a lead and the Test has been turned completely on its head. I feel like the last four hours have been an effortless dream – nothing about it gruelling whatsoever. As I’m sitting there in the dressing room, a stupid grin on my face, watching people hang around laughing and gawping at the shots being played on television, Matt Prior comes and sits next to me: ‘Only 19 more.’ *Only 19 more to what?* I think to myself. Then it strikes me. I am 81 not out in a Test match, only 19 short of a century. In that very moment – as if the pinch of reality and recognition grounds me to earth from a cartoon – I know that the dream is over. I’m going to overthink it now, it’s too much to contemplate.

I am, inevitably, immediately out as play restarts, the last session seemingly just a mirage that existed in its own parallel universe. The crowd gets to their feet and I soak up the applause, pointing my bat back at all the stands. We have put on 198 runs for the tenth wicket.

After the game, Joe gives me a bat, signing the handle ‘To the all-rounder, love Joe’. I have heard people say about Root from afar, teammates and media and coaches: ‘I don’t know how he does it.’ For one innings, I actually do. It’s a joy – a simplicity of expression that you can consider yourself privileged to have experienced just once. Joe had my back then – willing the whole thing true. He always did. And so did the rest of Trent Bridge, the vision of me being haunched over, tears in my eyes, only a month old, all of that made sense of now by what had moved through my system today. If you hang in there with the game long enough, it swoops back to teach you something that’s good for you, or repays you for your time. It’s all part of what makes Test cricket so great – suffering and joy – it reaches in and pulls out emotions and reserves within you that you didn’t know you had.